

Notes On Wing Commander: Privateer

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Notes: This document comes from my [github](#). Therein I also host my [articles](#) on retro games as well as the *Wing Commander fanfic* I am currently editing named *Vega Campaign*.

1. Introduction

Privateer is a different view on the *Wing Commander* universe where, surprisingly perhaps, the Terran-Kilrathi war still plays a major role in the story, but it is at the background. This happens because the hero, Grayson Burrows or Brownhair, is a freelancer operating in the Gemini sector, a relatively minor theater of operations. This fact allows for a more carefree civilian life compared to the Vega or the Enigma sectors named in the main war storyline. Of course, this holds as long as the systems along the border are avoid. Otherwise, the closer the player flies to them, the more likely Kilrathi are to appear. Not to mention stray pilots or even small Kilrathi flight groups venturing into Confederation space.

Being at the fringe of the Terran space, this frontier life is far from being uneventful with pirates roaming Gemini to prey on merchants across established trade routes, especially around their hidden bases where they operate *en masse* with almost total impunity. Moreover, the rather militant Retros, an offshoot of the peaceful Church of Man, despise anything based on technology even remotely. So when they more than occasionally appear in space, where everything from breathing to communicating and navigating inevitably relies on technology, they are there to disrupt literally everything.

In this chaotic environment the local militias in light fighters, assisted on occasion by Confederation InSys troops flying far more advanced crafts such as agile fighters, tough bombers, and even corvettes armed with a wide array of guns, are trying to maintain law and order by hunting down anyone carrying contraband or attacking merchants. As the local and Confederation forces are often vastly outnumbered, they resort to getting help from mercenaries who have their own fighters and tactics.

Where does Brownhair stand in all this? The answer is really open, as he is bound only by budgetary constraints and by your decisions. In Gemini only these shape your actions and your destiny ...

2. Notes

The material and ideas that follow is a compilation of posts on the *Wing Commander CIC* as well as of notes I took while replaying *Privateer* a number of times.

2.1. Ships

- I really love the Centurion, but I believe it is slightly overpowered with its four guns and two missile/torpedo launchers. So maybe Orion should get besides her strong shields a unique attack advantage. Maybe a scaled down/early gun cooler to be able to fire more blasts from the heavier guns, say at 1.2 or 1.5 times the original fire rate. I really like the ionic pulse cannon, despite its slow travelling bolts, so I would like to find a use for it.
- Adding a stormfire cannon would be fun, especially for the Orion which can carry additional rounds compared to the Centurion as it has more internal space. So mounting a stormfire in the single external fore hardpoint of Orion with a considerable number of rounds would make sense in the context of Orion being a mercenary gunship. Ok, Talons may well evade it and maybe Dralthis to some extent, but everything else .. After all why waste stormfire rounds on Talons?
- Additionally, there can be a third, more advanced and considerably more expensive repair droid which can actually manufacture a small number of rounds for stormfire when not busy repairing the ship. Maybe in Righteous Fire, but I could also see that in Privateer. Also the player should have the

necessary material aboard, perhaps iron or tungsten and gems. So there is an additional incentive for visiting the numerous mining bases scattered throughout Gemini.

- As for Galaxy, well not my favorite ship. Even for Ultimate (is that a pun on Ultima?) sugar runs I use Orion and just use afterburners to get past militia patrols in Humboldt. I guess it is ok for merchants, but remotely controlling the upper and lower turrets, at least partially, from the cockpit would offset to some extent its size and lack of agility. It is not a fighting ship, but it should stand a chance against four or five Talons.
- There may be modifications reducing the radar cross section of the player's ship, roughly equivalent to an ECM pack 3.5.
- Inspired from Peleus, there may be radar jamming devices used by capital ships giving to the player static up to 20% of the time. There may be smaller such devices used by larger ships like the Galaxy or the Orion giving static 10% of the time.

2.2. Space opponents

- Ok (former!) Governor Menesch sold myriads of Talons to pirates and retros, but why not some of these Gladius too? Or maybe some Broadwords used as pirate semi-capital or scout or coordination ships along with some Galaxies in the same role, after all we have seen the Black Rhombus.
- Also it would make sense that the retros occasionally fly Orions and Centurions as heavier fighters, after all they are in the open market.
- Miggs flying a Talon? No. I mean I doubt he can efficiently fly a Centurion, but at least for prestige he and his associates should fly ones.
- Also Miggs should have more friends with him, hoping to intimidate Brownhair, though I doubt he really wants the artifact.
- For immersion reasons, some of the pirate, militia, and Confederation crafts should be randomly damaged indicating a tough patrol.
- In the Fariss and Humboldt quadrants in particular, the player could randomly meet pirates doing business with dirty cops, so Brownhair has to eliminate ships of both factions. These can be plot missions alternatively.
- To further enhance immersion through player achievements, the kill breakdown should include the number of ace pilots as well as the number of capital ships for each faction downed by the player.

2.3. Missions

- In addition to system patrol missions, there should be system wipe missions aiming at eliminating all hostilities. These should be more likely to appear in smaller systems either closer to the Gemini frontier or to pirate bases.
- There should be bounties placed on flight groups.
- Defend base missions? Why not also an obliterate base one? Captain Goodin may well pay you to devastate a pirate base, giving strong vibes of the final Venice mission. After all, there are many of them in Fariss and in Humboldt quadrants, so one can be chosen at random. For this you will need at least five proton torpedoes and strong guns, ie ionic pulse cannons or plasma guns.
- Bring some Wing Commander vibes by flying escort for Paradigms or Broadwords. The game mechanics are already there from the Oxford plot missions.
- Turrets on asteroids around pirate bases armed with lasers or mass drivers. It would make perfect sense, especially in conjunction with the above.
- When the player talks to a bartender the first time after they dispatch Miggs, they could get a note from Lynch that this is not over. That would utilize the existing bar mechanic.
- There should be "system sheriff" side quests where the player acts as one for a predetermined number of missions.

- The scripted enemies in some of the cargo missions should not appear at the destination base as the player can just bypass them and land, even on a Tarsus. Maybe they should attack when the player takes off.

2.4. Maps and navigation

- As the player flies in the various systems, the hidden points and the asteroids are marked in Brownhair's star charts. This would give a sense of accomplishment to the player.
- If the player buys the entire star map pack, then the maps for the quadrants other than the one the player currently is in may contain random errors.
- If the player lands on a pirate base, then it is marked on their star maps. In subsequent militia or Confederation contraband check, these altered maps will show up and the player is marked as a pirate by that particular patrol as if they were carrying contraband.
- On pirate bases, random fixers may sell treasure maps which may or may not be hoaxes.
- Alternatively these fixers may offer random upgrades to the player's ship. Some may be temporary e.g. a Mace missile or thrust enhancement, whereas others may be permanent but not game changing e.g. tweaking the power generator to give 5% or 10% more energy.

References

- [My article on Privateer on Serpenter's Lair.](#)
- [Wing Commander CIC.](#)
- [Privateer on Wikipedia.](#)
- [Privateer on GOG.](#)
- [Privateer on Ars Technica.](#)
- [Privateer on tvtropes](#)